

8 December 2025

The National Food Council (the Council) met for the first time on Monday 8 December 2025. The meeting was attended by the Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry, the Hon Julie Collins MP and chaired by the Secretary of the Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry, Victoria Anderson.

Minister Collins welcomed members of the Council, reflecting that the establishment of this group is a key step in delivering a food security strategy that is developed in collaboration with all who have a stake in our food system – from primary producers and processors, to researchers and innovators, to the Australian public and our trading partners who rely on Australia’s food system to put food on their plate every day. Minister Collins noted that there was significant interest in the Council and that the members skills and experience in the room reflected the complexity and breadth of Australia’s food system.

Members of the Council, comprising industry and community experts from across the food system, acknowledged that there had been calls for many years from many stakeholders for the development of a strategy and a council to inform it and welcomed the opportunity to work together on this critical issue and to help shape a food security strategy for all Australians.

Minister Collins outlined her expectations of the Council and the scope of its activities. This will include providing advice on the development of the strategy, providing leadership and fostering collaboration between government, industry and community to achieve a strategy that will boost the productivity, resilience and security of our food system. Members also commenced discussions on a forward workplan and ways of working.

Members discussed the economic drivers of food security including receiving a presentation from Dr Jared Greenville, Executive Director of the Australian Bureau of Agricultural and Resource Economics and Sciences (ABARES). Members received a briefing on the development of the National Food Security Strategy, including the engagement and feedback to date from stakeholders. Members discussed the scope and direction of the strategy, providing views on priority areas for the strategy to consider. Members noted that the department will be undertaking a significant process of consultation and co-design in the first half of 2026 to enable stakeholders from across the food system to inform and contribute to the development of the strategy.

The Council will next meet in early 2026.

Attendees

- Dr Christopher Downs
- Mel Gatfield
- Andrew Henderson
- Barry Irvin AM
- Dr Elizabeth Jackson
- Dr Leisa McCarthy

- Su McCluskey
- Pat O'Shannassy
- David Stout
- Dr Tracy Sullivan
- The Hon Julie Collins MP, Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry
- Victoria Anderson, Secretary, Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry (Chair)
- Matt Lowe, Deputy Secretary, Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry Policy Group
- Joanna Stanion, First Assistant Secretary, Agricultural Policy Division
- Paul Denny, Assistant Secretary, Food Policy Branch
- Dr Jared Greenville, Executive Director, ABARES

Guest attendees

- John Body, ThinkPlace

Apologies

- Claire McClelland

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/about/news/stay-informed/communiques/national-food-council-dec-2025>